

ALLY QUINN: TRUE CRIME MERGE · ECHOES OF HAVENBAY

# Episode 1 — Three Pitches

Judged against episode-1-pilot-spec.md · openings are verbatim node text · 10 July 2026

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# The Overnight Girl

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## LOGLINE

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*Nina Vasquez works the overnight shift at the Corner Diner and ends every break the same way — she rings her kid brother twice at 3:10 a.m. and hangs up: I'm okay, go back to sleep. Tonight the phone rang three times, the line stayed open for forty silent seconds, and Nina was gone before her coffee order came up. The police say adults are allowed to leave. Her brother says she'd never break the signal — and Ally has until the trail freezes to find a woman who saw something through the diner window that she was never meant to see.*

## VICTIM & KEEPER

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Nina (24) — alive, running, hunted. Keeper: Marco Vasquez (17), her brother, who she raised after their mother left, and who has kept his phone on loud every night for six years.

## THE SECRET

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On her 3 a.m. break Nina watched two men load something man-shaped from a van into the fish market's ice store across the street. One of them saw her seeing. She ran before end of shift and has been moving between night places ever since — because the man looking for her is patient, professional, and has done this before.

## REVEAL LADDER

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1. The 40-second voicemail has diner sounds *and a second door chime* — someone followed her out.
2. The ice store manifest for that night is missing a pallet.
3. Nina has been sighted — alive, moving through overnight places, terrified.
4. The man asking about her at those same places is always one stop behind — or ahead.
5. Climax: Ally reaches her first — or is led to her; the man was following *Ally*.
6. Whisper: the diner till roll shows someone paid Nina's tab at 3:12 that night. Cash. Nobody remembers him. **The tip jar holds a coin nobody can place.**

## BRANCH (PHASE 2)

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Broadcast Nina's face and name — the city finds her faster, but so does he — or keep her name off the air and hunt quiet. Players will argue about this one in reviews.

## CANON USAGE

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Corner Diner (ties the diner item family and generator into the story), Harbor Ward fish market, Del Cruz (the cop who admits "adults are allowed to disappear" and hates it), Mo's Anchor as a night-place waypoint. New faces (portraits): Nina, Marco, the diner owner.

## OPENING — L1 · "THE 3:10 CALL" (PODCAST, VO)

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| SPEAKER | EMOTION | LINE |
|---------|---------|------|
|---------|---------|------|

|   |             |         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---|-------------|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Ally</b> | neutral | Every night at ten past three, a phone in a teenager's bedroom rings twice and stops. That's the whole message. It means: I'm okay, go back to sleep. It has rung twice a night for six years.                                                 |
| 2 | <b>Ally</b> | worried | Last night it rang three times. Then forty seconds of open line — a coffee machine, a door chime, another door chime — and nothing since. Nina Vasquez walked out of the Corner Diner mid-shift and into none of the places she has ever been. |
| 3 | <b>Ally</b> | neutral | The police say adults are allowed to leave. They're right. But Marco played me the voicemail four times and asked the only question that matters: why two door chimes? Nina walked out alone.                                                  |
| 4 | <b>Ally</b> | neutral | I drink my coffee at that diner. I know that door. This is Echoes of Havenbay. I'm Ally Quinn, and somebody left forty seconds behind her — I intend to find the rest.                                                                         |

# The Confession

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## LOGLINE

*At two in the morning an old man sits down in Gerald's booth at the Rusty Anchor, tells him "I killed a man at the Rivermouth foundry in 1989, and saying it out loud is my funeral" — and is dead of a tidy heart attack before dawn. The police pat Gerald on the head like a confused old-timer. Ally sets out to prove her grandfather's ears — and discovers the confession was true, the confessor was innocent, and whoever has kept 1989 buried for thirty-seven years just found out that a Quinn was listening.*

## VICTIM & KEEPER

Frank Doyle (81) — a man paid decades ago to hold a lie, silenced the night he tried to put it down. Keeper: **Gerald** — this is his episode; the case is his credibility, his guilt about what old cops overlooked, and his booth. Secondary keeper: June Calloway (64), sister of the man who burned in 1989, told her whole life her brother was drunk on shift.

## THE SECRET

Doyle didn't kill anyone. In 1989 he was paid to be the fall guy if the foundry fire ever came unstuck — a standing arrangement, maintained by someone who has quietly paid him a pension for silence ever since. The real killer died a month ago; Doyle thought that freed him. It didn't. The arrangement had a survivor — the payer — and Dr. Cortez finds the injection site the "heart attack" left behind.

## REVEAL LADDER

1. The confession recording exists — Ally's rig was live at the Anchor that night.
2. Cortez: the heart attack had help.
3. 1989: the file says accident, June's brother blamed — but Doyle wasn't even on shift. The confession was a purchased script.
4. Doyle's bank: a pension from a trust paying monthly since 1989 — and paying *someone else* too.
5. Climax: Gerald finds a drink at his booth he didn't order — "from a friend." The payer knows who heard.
6. Whisper: among Doyle's effects, **a coin, minted 1989, uncirculated** — carried thirty-seven years like a leash.

## BRANCH (PHASE 2)

Air Gerald's recording of the confession — making Gerald a public witness (attention protects him, or paints the target brighter) — or withhold it and work in the dark. The player is choosing what risk the grandfather carries. That's the argument.

## CANON USAGE

The Rusty Anchor and Gerald's booth as the crime scene of a *word*; Mo (she seated Doyle; she keeps confidences and this one hurts); Dr. Cortez (first appearance, the injection site); Rivermouth Industrial

(1989 foundry); Del Cruz at the reopening. New faces (portraits): Doyle (one scene, unforgettable), June, Mo.

## OPENING — L1 · "THE MAN IN THE BOOTH" (PODCAST, VO)

|   | SPEAKER | EMOTION | LINE                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---|---------|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Ally    | neutral | My grandfather has sat in the same booth at the Rusty Anchor for thirty years. Cops sat across from him, then crooks, then mostly just me. Last night a stranger sat down, and I got a phone call at 2 a.m.                          |
| 2 | Ally    | worried | "There was a dead man in my booth tonight, love." Gerald doesn't rattle. He was rattled. The stranger had leaned across the table and said: I killed a man at the Rivermouth foundry in 1989 — and saying it out loud is my funeral. |
| 3 | Ally    | sad     | By six this morning, Frank Doyle was dead in his flat. Heart attack, they said. Natural causes, they said. And the officers taking my grandfather's statement wrote slowly, the way you do for a man you've decided is old.          |
| 4 | Ally    | neutral | Here's what they don't know. My rig was still live from the evening show. Every word Frank Doyle said is on tape — and Gerald Quinn has never misheard a confession in his life. This is Echoes of Havenbay. Episode one.            |

# Dead Air

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## LOGLINE

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*Seventeen years ago, Havenbay's midnight radio host Marguerite "Mags" Okonkwo died live on air, mid-sentence — and the station engineer cut to music so the city never heard her final ninety seconds. Friday, the condemned station building goes under Councillor Hart's wrecking ball. Tuesday, a demolition surveyor mails Ally the reel marked DO NOT AIR. Wednesday, someone empties Ally's mailbox. The tape is gone, the building has three days to live — and whatever Mags said with her last breath, somebody has spent seventeen years making sure nobody hears it.*

## VICTIM & KEEPER

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Mags — the voice that taught thirteen-year-old Ally, in the year after her father died, that the dark answers if you speak into it. Keeper: Ray Delgado (58), the engineer who cut the feed, who has believed for seventeen years that he let her die alone off-air.

## THE SECRET

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Mags had been taking midnight calls from a frightened city clerk about land parcels bought through dead men's names. She said so, on air, with the clerk's first name, in the ninety seconds Ray cut. The clerk "jumped" a week later. The fixer who handled both is old now, comfortable, and still keeps a key to a building that stopped mattering to everyone else — because the booth wall holds what Mags hid.

## REVEAL LADDER

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1. The surveyor kept a 20-second phone recording of the reel: *"...if this is my last broadcast, check the booth wall..."*
2. Death certificate: aneurysm — but the station log shows a visitor signed in at 11:58 who never signed out.
3. The clerk's "suicide" a week later, connected by nobody until now.
4. Inside the condemned building (climax, against the demolition clock): the wall cache — her notebook and the reel's twin.
5. Ray hears the real last ninety seconds: Mags wasn't afraid, she was *furios*, and she finished her sentence.
6. Whisper: in the reel canister, **a coin** — and a sign-in signature at 11:58 that Ally photographs without recognizing.

## BRANCH (PHASE 2)

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Air the lost broadcast complete — including the dead clerk's name, which his surviving family begged the city to forget — or redact ninety seconds the way Ray once did, and carry what that rhymes with.

## CANON USAGE

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Stonebridge Viaduct / Arts Quarter station, Hart Civic Center redevelopment (season texture without unmasking), Arthur Finch (he covered Mags's death in 2009 and kept his doubts), Del Cruz for demolition-

site access. New faces (portraits): Ray, the surveyor, Mags (archival, one flashback style).

OPENING — L1 · "THE REEL" (PODCAST, VO)

|   | SPEAKER | EMOTION   | LINE                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---|---------|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Ally    | neutral   | When I was thirteen and the house had gone quiet in the worst way, I listened to a radio show that started at midnight. Mags Okonkwo. She used to say: the dark answers, if you speak into it properly.                    |
| 2 | Ally    | sad       | She died on air when I was fourteen. Mid-sentence. The city heard four bars of jazz where her last words should have been, and we called that a mercy.                                                                     |
| 3 | Ally    | surprised | Tuesday, a demolition surveyor mailed me a reel from the condemned station. Hand-labelled, her handwriting: DO NOT AIR — FINAL. It sat in my mailbox for one night. By morning the mailbox was open and the reel was gone. |
| 4 | Ally    | neutral   | Seventeen years, and it still isn't safe to hear her finish a sentence. The wrecking ball swings Friday. This is Echoes of Havenbay — and this week, I speak into the dark for both of us.                                 |

RECOMMENDATION

**B — "The Confession", by a nose.** It puts the jeopardy on the character players already love, makes Gerald's booth — the game's warmest place — the scene of the crime, gives the tutorial episode the show's central relationship, and its branch is genuinely agonizing: you are choosing your grandfather's risk profile. **A** has the strongest pure cold open and the tightest premise-in-one-sentence; if day-1 retention is the only god, choose A. **C** is the most distinctive and the most thematic (it's about why Ally exists) — arguably the best episode, but its register is elegy where a pilot may want pulse.

All three: whisper lands as an unexplained coin; Thomas touched lightly; one recurring-cast introduction each; first-three-leads map cleanly to merge goals. Franken-picking is legal — A's branch with B's case, C's opening register with either.